

LEVEL 3 (6-8TH GRADE)

DEVELOPING CHARACTERS

BASIC CONCEPT: Your character must be solidified physically. Is your character a girl or a boy? How old is he? What does she look like? When and where does your character live? What will his or her name be? Dressing your character to match the era and place in which he lives will help immerse the reader. Does your character have friends? Naming her can be difficult, but the character's name is (often) important, especially if you are writing your story in third person (writing from an external point of view, for example, saying "he picked up the book" instead of "I picked up the book"). Remember that although how the character *looks* is important, the real magic happens when you develop the character's other traits.

DEVELOPING DETAILS: Now develop things about the character that aren't necessarily obvious just by looking at him or her. What are your character's hobbies? What are her hopes? Is he shy? Does she fidget when worried? What's something that bothers him? Is she good at math? Can he run quickly? Make sure to incorporate both strengths and weaknesses into your character, to keep him or her interesting and relatable to your readers. Keep in mind that there can be physical attributes that result from these traits (for example, if your character likes to paint, she might have paint on her hands and clothes.)

IMPORTANT NOTE: If your character is a villain, you should let the readers know *why* he or she is doing the "bad" things that would make people consider him or her a villain. Saying that he's a villain "just because he wants to be" doesn't make him interesting enough. There needs to be a legitimate motive to her actions. For example, perhaps the hero of the story accidentally stole something that belonged to the villain because that thing was a tool that could be used to save the world. Now, the villain spends her time trying to get the thing back. In addition to this, villains that aren't *purely* evil can be interesting characters. For example, you can make your readers curious about the villain and perhaps sympathetic for him by letting him save a kitten from a snowstorm.